TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Python leads at 21.25% — but C surges to #2 while Go drops 9 places

DATA ANALYSIS REPORT · MARCH 2026

Python holds #1 at 21.25% but C surges to #2 with the largest gain (+2.02 pp); top 4 languages = 49% of index

RANK '26	RANK '25	LANGUAGE	RATING	YoY CHANGE	CALLOUT	BAR
1	1	**Python**	**21.25%**	▼ -2.59%		
2	4	**C**	11.55%	▲ +2.02%		
3	2	C++	8.18%	▼ -2.90%		
4	3	Java	7.99%	▼ -2.37%		
5	5	C#	6.36%	▲ +1.49%		
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	▼ -0.01%		
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	▼ -0.02%		
8	8	SQL	2.00%	▼ -0.57%		
9	**16**	**R**	1.88%	**▲ +0.94%**		
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	▼ -0.36%		
11	**24**	**Perl**	1.75%	**▲ +1.05%**		
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	▼ -0.03%		
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	▼ -0.25%		
14	14	Rust	1.31%	▲ +0.09%		
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	▲ +0.31%		
16	**7**	**Go**	1.29%	**▼ -1.49%**		
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	▲ +0.42%		
18	13	PHP	1.23%	▼ -0.25%		
19	18	Ada	1.10%	▲ +0.25%		
20	**26**	**Swift**	1.04%	**▲ +0.44%**		

TOP 4 CONCENTRATION

48.97%

Python + C + C++ + Java = nearly half of index

- Gained rank or rating YoY
- Lost rank or rating YoY

Prior rank shown in '25 column

★ Notable movers highlighted

Perl jumps 13 spots, R climbs 7, and Go drops 9 — the biggest rank shifts of 2026

BIGGEST GAINERS

#11 ▲ 13 ranks (was #24)
Perl +1.05 pp — Scientific computing legacy entrenched

#9 ▲ 7 ranks (was #16)
R +0.94 pp — Data analysis community strong and growing

#20 ▲ 6 ranks (was #26)
Swift +0.44 pp — Re-enters top 20; Apple platform growth

#2 ▲ 2 ranks (was #4)
C +2.02 pp — Largest absolute rating gain in top 5

#5 → — (held #5)
C# +1.49 pp — Rating gain; 2023 & 2025 Language of Year

BIGGEST LOSERS

#16 ▼ 9 ranks (was #7)
Go -1.49 pp — Largest absolute drop; Rust rising at #14

#3 ▼ 1 rank (was #2)
C++ -2.90 pp — Largest % drop in top 5

#4 ▼ 1 rank (was #3)
Java -2.37 pp — Long decline from ~25% peak (2005–2018)

#18 ▼ 5 ranks (was #13)
PHP -0.25 pp — Continued erosion in web-backend space

#22 ▼ exit (was in top 20)
Kotlin — Exits top 20; Swift re-enters

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026 — 40 years of shifting dominance; C is the only constant

LONG-TERM RANKING HISTORY · NINE LANGUAGES ACROSS FOUR DECADES

LANGUAGE	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	**1**	**3**	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C ONLY CONSTANT	**2**	**1**	**2**	**2**	**2**	**1**	**1**	**1**	**1**
C++	**3**	**4**	**3**	**3**	**3**	**2**	**2**	**2**	9
Java	4	2	**1**	**1**	**1**	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	16	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	**3**
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	**4**	**2**

Top-3 rank   Gray numbers = ranked 11–40   — = unranked in TIOBE at that time

Python: 25-Year Ascent
Unranked before 1991. Entered top-30 only in 2001 (rank 26). Surged to #1 after 2018, peaked above 25%, settling at 21.25%.

C: The Only Constant
Ranked #1 or #2 across all 9 measurement points spanning four decades (1986–2026). No other language matches this.

Lisp: From #2 to #26
#2 in 1986, now ranked 26th. Java: dominated 2005–2018 from ~25%, now under 8%. Dominance is never permanent.

JavaScript: never exceeded ~5% on TIOBE despite web dominance (currently 3.45%). Ada peaked at #3 in 1986, now #14.

Python wins Language of the Year 6 times — more than any other language (C# second with 3)

TIOBE PROGRAMMING LANGUAGE OF THE YEAR · GOES TO LANGUAGE WITH LARGEST ANNUAL RATING GAIN

2025
C# .NET Ecosystem
Back-to-back 2023 & 2025

2024
Python 6× Winner
6th win (2007,2010,2018,2020,2021)

2023
C# 2023 & 2025 Winner
Driven by growing .NET adoption

2022
C++
Systems programming resurgence

2021
Python
5th win — AI/ML adoption surge

2020
Python
4th win — data science era

2019
C
Embedded systems & IoT momentum

2018
Python
3rd win

2017
N/A
Data not available in source

2016
Go Now #16 (▼9 ranks)
Win preceded its steepest decline

Strategic Insight: What the Hall of Fame Reveals

Python (6×): unmatched sustained growth across multiple eras — scripting (2007–2010) → data science (2018–2020) → AI/ML (2021–2024)

C# (3×): growing momentum — driven by .NET ecosystem expansion, game development (Unity), and enterprise adoption

Go 2016 win: winning "Language of the Year" does not guarantee sustained growth — context and ecosystem fit matter more

The top 4 languages hold 49% of the index: what this means for your tech stack

MONITOR PYTHON & C

21.25%

Python rating — more than double #2

▼ 2.59 pp

Python's largest YoY decline in the top 5

▲ 2.02 pp

C's largest YoY gain — now firmly at #2

Implication:

Python is still the dominant hiring target.
C's resurgence warrants renewed investment in embedded/systems talent pipelines.
Don't treat Python's lead as permanent.

Monitor C's continued trajectory.

C# +1.49 pp: .NET ecosystem stable & growing.

LEGACY LANGUAGES REVIVE

+13 ranks

Perl 24th → 11th (+1.05 pp)

R: 16th → 9th

Data analysis community holds strong (+0.94 pp)

Fortran: Top 15

Scientific computing, HPC: still relevant

Implication:

Entrenched scientific, data analysis, and infrastructure communities resist migration.
Factor Perl, R, and Fortran into hiring plans for data-heavy or legacy system work.

Replacement strategies should be evidence-based, not assumption-based.

GO'S SHARP DECLINE

-9 ranks

Go: 7th → 16th (−1.49 pp) — largest drop

Rust: #14

Steady at +0.09 pp; systems alternative rising

Kotlin exits top 20

Swift re-enters at #20 (+0.44 pp)

Implication:

If your stack is Go-heavy, evaluate Rust as a systems-language alternative now.
Go is still top-20 — don't panic — but monitor its continued trajectory closely.

For mobile: Swift's iOS-first trajectory means Kotlin/cross-platform needs review.

CONCENTRATION RISK

Python + C + C++ + Java = **48.97%** of total TIOBE index. With 50+ tracked languages, the field is concentrated.

ACTION ITEM

Breadth in hiring and tooling reduces single-language risk. Build portfolios, not m